HAMPI: CAPITAL OF THE VIJAYANAGARA EMPIRE (????)

HISTORICAL SPLENDOR ON THE TUNGABHADRA

Hampi, designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1986, was the imperial capital of the Vijayanagara Empire from 1336 to 1565 CE. Founded by the Sangama brothers Harihara I and Bukka Raya I along the banks of the Tungabhadra River in Vijayanagara district (formerly Bellary), Hampi grew into one of the largest and wealthiest metropolises in the medieval world.

THE REIGN OF EMPEROR KRISHNADEVARAYA

The empire attained its cultural and political golden age under Emperor Krishnadevaraya of the Tuluva dynasty (reigned 1509?1529 CE), a visionary patron of arts, literature, and monumental temple construction. The rugged boulder-strewn landscape features over 1,600 surviving monuments across 41 square kilometers.

KEY MONUMENTS OF HAMPI

1. Virupaksha Temple Complex:
The primary and continuously functioning pilgrimage center dedicated to Lord Shiva (Virupaksha/Pampa). Features a towering 50-meter eastern gopuram, extensive pillared halls, and ceiling murals from the 16th century.

2. Vijaya Vittala Temple & Stone Chariot:
The crowning achievement of Vijayanagara architecture, dedicated to Lord Vishnu. Renowned for the iconic monolithic Stone Chariot (Garuda shrine) featured on the Indian 50-rupee currency note. The grand Ranga Mandapa contains 56 monolithic musical pillars (sa-re-ga-ma pillars) carved with resonant stone shafts.

3. Royal Enclosure & Secular Architecture:
The administrative core containing the stepped tank (Pushkarani), Mahanavami Dibba platform used for state festivals, the Queen's Bath, the two-storeyed Lotus Mahal with elegant arched cusps in Indo-Islamic style, and the massive eleven-chambered Elephant Stables.